



NCL Aqua — All Aboard, Veterans

December 12 – 19, 2027 · Tina Maulsby, host

Ship: Norwegian Aqua · **Sailing from:** Port Canaveral · **Cabin:** _____

A condensed Voyage Pack from [In the Wake](#) — the essentials in three pages. The full pack covers cabins, packing, budget, ship orientation, NCL's quirks, the veterans group rhythm, and accessibility considerations for service-connected disabilities.

Day by day

#	Date	Port	Hours ashore	Tender	Worth knowing
1	Sun Dec 12	Port Canaveral — embarkation	board 12:00 – 3:30 PM; depart 4:00 PM	—	All-aboard 3 PM. Sailaway from Ocean Boulevard Deck 8.
2	Mon Dec 13	Cruising at sea	—	—	Settling-in day. Studio Lounge solo meet-and-greet.
3	Tue Dec 14	Great Stirrup Cay (NCL)	~10:00 AM – 6:00 PM	tender	NCL's private island. Beach + buffet day. Mid-redevelopment — manage expectations.
4	Wed Dec 15	Cruising at sea	—	—	Second sea day. Specialty dining bookings.
5	Thu Dec 16	Jamaica (Ocho Rios / Falmouth / Montego Bay)	~10:00 AM – 5:00 PM	—	Dunn's River Falls climb (\$60 ship / \$30 indep) or stay at Island Village pier complex.
6	Fri Dec 17	Grand Cayman	~8:00 AM – 4:00 PM	tender	Stingray City sandbar (~\$60 indep) or 7-Mile Beach (~\$5 bus).
7	Sat Dec 18	Cozumel, Mexico	~9:00 AM – 7:00 PM	—	Palancar Reef snorkel (~\$50 indep) — the Western Caribbean dive.
8	Sun Dec 19	Port Canaveral — debarkation	off by 10:00 AM	—	Orlando MCO airport ~45 min Uber (\$60–80).

Verify your Jamaica port with Tina. This pack assumes Ocho Rios; the actual sailing may use Falmouth or Montego Bay.

Two tender ports — Great Stirrup and Grand Cayman. Plan for 20–30 min end-to-end at peak.

For veterans: accessibility considerations and service-dog protocols are covered in the full pack. Auto-gratuity may be waived or reduced under VA-related programs — verify with Tina.

Currency aboard: USD. **Auto-gratuity:** \$20/day per person at most cabins; \$25/day Suites/Haven.

Decide before you board. Run the [drink-calculator](#) on your real drinking pattern, the [budget-calculator](#) for the total-fare picture, and the [tipping-calculator](#) for auto-grats + cash tips — mid-sail upgrades cost more per day and give you fewer days of usage.

Getting to the ship — and getting home

Arrival: Saturday recommended, Sunday required

Saturday Dec 11 — fly in. December weather is generally good in Central Florida, but Sunday-morning flights to a 3:30 PM all-aboard leave no margin for delays. Pre-cruise hotel near Orlando MCO (cheaper) or in Cocoa Beach (closer to the port) gives breathing room.

Sunday Dec 12 — embarkation.

- **Terminal: Port Canaveral, Cruise Terminal 10** (NCL's regular berth — verify).
- **MCO → Port Canaveral:** Uber/Lyft \$60–80, 45–60 min. Shared cruise shuttle ~\$30/person, slower.
- **If driving:** Port Canaveral garage ~\$17–22/day (cheaper than PortMiami); reservable in advance.
- **Embark window:** 12:00 – 3:30 PM. **All-aboard 3:00 PM.** Ship departs 4:00 PM.
- **NCL app online check-in** — complete before arrival.

Cocoa Beach overnight option. If you'd rather be 15 minutes from the port than 45, a Cocoa Beach hotel Saturday night puts you walking distance to the beach Sunday morning before boarding.

Day 8 debark and the trip home

- **The night before:** bags in the hall by ~11 PM with color-coded tag.
- **5:30 – 7:00 AM:** Breakfast at Indulge Food Hall.
- **6:30 AM:** Customs clearance complete. Self-disembarkation begins.
- **7:00 – 9:30 AM:** Walk-off in waves. All passengers off by 10:00 AM.

Carry-on with you: change of clothes, all medications, passport, phone charger, valuables.

Getting from Port Canaveral to MCO. Uber/Lyft \$60–80, 45–60 min. Cocoa Beach Shuttle (~\$30/person, advance booking) is the formal alternative.

Killing 4–6 hours before an evening flight:

- **Cocoa Beach pier** — 15-min Uber. Beach walk + casual lunch.
- **Kennedy Space Center** — 20-min Uber, \$75 entry. Half-day minimum.
- **Cocoa Village** — historic small-town main street; lunch + shops.

Airport-arrival timing for MCO (45+ minutes away):

Flight	Leave Port Canaveral by
Domestic, after 4 PM	12:30 PM
International, after 6 PM	2:00 PM

Areas of interest during the cruise

On the ship — Aqua spots worth knowing

- **The Penrose Atrium** — three-deck central gathering space; orienting landmark.
- **Ocean Boulevard** — outdoor wraparound walkway Deck 8. Sunrise coffee, sailaway viewing.
- **Indulge Food Hall** — included quick-casual with multiple stations.
- **Aqua Slidecoaster** — the signature attraction. First hour after opening has no line.
- **Studio Lounge** (Deck 11) — solo cabins perk. Hosted coffee hour Day 2 morning typically.
- **Mandara Spa thermal-suite day pass** — sea-day intro rates.
- **The Haven** (private suite enclave) — if you booked Haven, the private restaurant, lounge, and pool deck are the point.
- **Cagney's Steakhouse** — the included-line steakhouse standard.

Sea-day priorities (Day 2 + Day 4)

1. **Sunrise on Ocean Boulevard** — best 30 minutes of the week.
2. **Studio Lounge meet-and-greet** Day 2 — NCL hosts this; check the daily program.
3. **Aqua Slidecoaster** first hour after opening.
4. **Thermal suite at Mandara Spa** — sea-day intro rate.
5. **Specialty dining reservation** for Day 4 evening — Cagney's, Le Bistro, Palomar, Onda by Scarpetta all fill.

Specialty dining picks

- **Cagney's Steakhouse** — the steakhouse celebration meal.
- **Le Bistro** — French; the most romantic specialty room.
- **Onda by Scarpetta** — modern Italian, Scott Conant partnership.
- **Palomar** — Mediterranean-Latin fusion.
- **Sukhothai + Hasuki** — Asian; teppanyaki is the hibachi room.

Port-day picks (one each)

- **Great Stirrup Cay** — NCL's private island under redevelopment. Tender required. Beach + buffet day.
- **Jamaica** (Ocho Rios / Falmouth / Montego Bay) — Dunn's River Falls climb (~\$30 indep, \$60 ship) is the iconic. Or stay at the pier complex (Island Village) for the easy day. Mystic Mountain bobsled + zipline (~\$120) is the splurge.
- **Grand Cayman** — Stingray City sandbar (~\$60 indep) is the highest-value half-day. Or 7-Mile Beach (~\$5 #1 bus) for the easy day.
- **Cozumel** — Palancar Reef snorkel (~\$50 indep / ~\$95 ship). The trip that converts non-snorkelers. *The Western Caribbean* dive.

Where Tina sets the rhythm

- **Day 1 sailaway** — Penrose Bar typically; verify Tina's communications.
- **Group dinners** — likely Hudson's or one of the included MDRs; show up when you want.
- **Studio Lounge** — solo cruisers cluster regardless of who's hosting.

Photo spots worth knowing

- **Sailaway from Ocean Boulevard Deck 8** — Cape Canaveral coastline at golden hour.
- **The Penrose Atrium** at evening — three-deck chandelier moment.
- **Dunn's River Falls climb** — bring an underwater camera; the climb gets wet.
- **Palancar Reef** from the snorkel boat — underwater shots worth saving.

Need an at-home emergency handoff card? Separate one-page doc — ask Tina or download from [In the Wake](#). The full Voyage Pack is the unabridged companion document. Soli Deo Gloria.